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DELIVERY OF SERVICES

BLACK ADOLESCENTS AND YOUTH: An Endangered Species

Jewelle Taylor Gibbs, M.S.W., Ph.D.

School of Social Welfare, University of California, Berkeley

An analysis of major social indicators shows that black youth are relatively worse off in the 1980s than they were in 1960 in rates of unemployment, delinquency, substance abuse, teenage pregnancy, and suicide. Collaborative efforts among social service agencies, community organizations, and parents to develop preventive approaches to these interrelated problems are urged, and a national policy for children and families is called for.

Webster defines *species* as "a class of individuals having common attributes and designated by a common name" and *endangered* as being exposed to ". . . danger or peril of probable harm or loss."[46] Black youth in contemporary American society can aptly be described as an endangered species. Educators have written them off as unteachable, the juvenile justice system has failed to rehabilitate them, the mental health system has virtually ignored or excluded them, and social welfare institutions seem ill-equipped to respond to their multiple problems. They are, in an irretrievable sense, rejects of the affluent society.

In 1980 there were 10.5 million black youth under the age of 19 in the United States, with nearly three million in the 15–19 age group; another three million were 20–24 years of age.[31] Since this under-24 age group comprised approximately 50% of the total black population, the median age for blacks was 25 years, while the median age for whites was 41.[47] Thus, the black population is a relatively youthful population compared to whites and, as such, is more deeply affected by social and economic

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problems that have a direct impact upon teenagers and young adults. Although there are currenlty more middle-income black families and more black college students than during any previous period in U.S. history, there are also more blacks on welfare and more severe problems among the majority of black youth who are neither middle class nor college bound.

While every other demographic group has made progress in the last 20 years in terms of the major social indicators, black youth in the 15–24 age group have performed less well on five out of six of these indicators. Recent data from the 1980 census and other federal government sources indicate that, compared to 1960, more black youth are unemployed, in the juvenile justice system, involved in substance abuse, having babies out-of-wedlock, and committing suicide. The only improvement in 20 years, and that is of dubious significance, is in a reduction of high school dropout rates. A closer look at these social indicators will underscore the negative trends for black youth in the past two decades.*

SOCIAL INDICATORS

Education

A surface familiarity with the statistics on the educational attainment of black youth suggests that there has been some improvement in the past two decades. For example, in 1981, 15.4% of black youth in the 16–24 age group were high school dropouts, as compared to 23.8% in 1960.[31] In the 15–17 age group, 7.9% were dropouts in 1981, a considerable reduction from 22.3% in 1960. However, this figure does not reveal the number of black high school graduates who were functionally illiterate or barely able to fill out a job application. While an earlier survey estimated that over 20% of black male adolescents in the 12–17 age group were unable to read at the fourth grade level,[5] more recent statistics indicated that 21% of all blacks 18 and 19 years old and 25% of all those 20 and 21 years old had neither completed nor were presently enrolled in high school in 1980.[38] Thus, more than one out of five black youths in the 18–21 age group currently does not have the basic certificate which is necessary in our society for most entry-level jobs, apprenticeship programs, military service, or post-secondary education.

While reasons for dropping out of high school are varied, a recent Urban League Study[47] pointed out that many black male teenagers leave because of family economic problems, academic difficulties or disciplinary problems, while females often drop out due to pregnancy. This study also reported that nearly one-third of black families with incomes below $6000 had at least one child suspended from school, as did 18% of black families with incomes above $20,000.[47] These figures suggest that black students have attitudinal or behavioral problems which school administrators and teachers are either unwilling or unable to deal with effectively. Lack of communication between parents and school authorities, as well as prevailing community attitudes toward the schools, probably contributes to bureaucratic inflexibility, student alienation and hostility in a continuously escalating cycle of mistrust and maladaptive behavior.

* In several instances, the statistical figures from 1960 and earlier years and the more recent figures are not strictly comparable due to differences in data bases, sampling, and methods of reporting. Where these differences have not been noted in the text, it is assumed that they would not significantly alter the comparisons made and the conclusions drawn.

Whether black teenagers drop out of school or obtain a meaningless high school diploma based on "social promotion," the consequences are higher rates of unemployment, fewer options for jobs, greater welfare dependency, and long-range limitations on their social and economic mobility.

Youth Unemployment

In October 1983, the U.S. Labor Department announced a decline in the overall national rate of unemployment to 8.8%, but unemployment among black youth had risen to 48.3%, which was more than twice the 21.6% rate among all teenagers.* Four times greater than the unemployment rate of 12.1% among black youth, ages 16–19, in 1960, and comprising nearly half of the nation's black teenagers, this extremely high unemployment rate has significant implications for black youth in the 1980s. If they are unable to find jobs, they will not develop work skills, attitudes and habits which are appropriate and necessary in a competitive, highly technological economy. Moreover, recent studies have indicated that chronically unemployed black males constitute a disproportionately high percentage of those workers who become "discouraged" and completely drop out of the job-seekers market.[1] Without gainful employment, they will be increasingly tempted to participate in the underground alternative economy of the urban ghettos—the illegal system of barter in stolen goods, drugs, gambling, and prostitution.

The prospect of a rapidly increasing cadre of unemployed and unemployable urban youth socialized to a nonproductive life on the streets has major implications in terms of the development of a permanent urban underclass with its attendant sociopolitical consequences.[1,17]

Delinquency and Crime

The rate of delinquency among black youth has increased from 19.6% of all juvenile arrests in 1960 to 21.4% in 1979; thus 456,638 or approximately 15% of all black adolescents in the 15–19 age group were arrested in 1979.[45]

Black juveniles were arrested more frequently for robbery, rape, homicide, and aggravated assault than were whites. They were also more likely than white juveniles to be arrested for violent personal crimes, disorderly conduct, sexual misbehavior, and handling stolen property. In 1980, black youth committed 51% of the violent juvenile crime in the U.S. and only 26% of the total property crime.[45] Since blacks constitute about 12% of the population and account for 21% of all juvenile arrests, it can easily be seen that black juveniles are disproportionately more likely to be arrested than whites. In 1979, it was reported that 26% of all juveniles in public and private juvenile residential facilities were black, with an average age of 14.9 years.[45]

While some studies have suggested that black teens are more likely to be arrested, booked, and remanded for trial and to receive harsher dispositions than whites, it has also been suggested that black youth may be arrested more frequently for minor offenses both because inner-city neighborhoods are patrolled more intensively and because police overreact to the negative attitudes and "antiauthority demeanor" of black

* Reported in the *San Francisco Chronicle*, Nov. 5, 1983, p.1.

youth.[44] Whether or not these factors can continue to account for the widespread discrepancy between arrest rates of black and white youth, the fact remains that black youth are disproportionately involved in the juvenile justice system, resulting in severe limitations on their educational and occupational opportunities and creating a vicious cycle of delinquency, incarceration, recidivism, and chronic criminal careers, or unemployment and marginal social adaptation in adulthood.

Moreover, the primary victims of black juvenile crime are the juveniles themselves and the black community. Homicide is the second leading cause of death among black youth in the 15–24 age group. In 1980 alone, more than 2000 black youth, ages 10–19, were murdered, most of them by other black teenagers.[45] In addition, the rate of victimization for crimes of violence is generally greater for blacks at all income levels and the victimization rate of residents of central cities is roughly twice that of residents of urban and suburban areas.[45] In 1980, 95% of those who committed crimes against blacks were themselves black, and the majority of these crimes were committed by youth under the age of 24.[45] Inner-city neighborhoods are increasingly becoming brutalized by youth who burglarize stores and homes, vandalize schools and churches, and terrorize those who are old, sick, and vulnerable. The major victims of these antisocial youth are black females, age 25 or older, black males in the 50–64 age group, and other black male teenagers in the 12–15 age group.[45]

Substance Abuse

Recent data from the National Institute on Drug Abuse indicates that nonwhite youth in the 18–25 age group have higher or equal rates of drug abuse than white youth in every major drug category except for inhalants and hallucinogens.[32] Among the younger age group, 12–17, 31% of black teens reported they had used marijuana and 29% said they had used alcohol in this 1979 NIDA survey. The mortality rate from drug-related deaths has increased dramatically in nine major metropolitan areas since 1973, with about one-third of those fatalities occurring among black youth in the 15–24 age group.[9]

Drug abuse among black youth has not only increased in the past 20 years, it has also spread from the inner cities into the suburbs and the users have become progressively involved with "hard drugs" such as heroin and cocaine, which are inextricably tied to street crime. Moreover, a NIDA study has predicted an increase in drug abuse among black and Hispanic youth through 1995 because they constitute the fastest-growing segment of the population and because of their current usage patterns.[7] In 1980, 27% of the clients admitted to federally-funded drug-abuse treatment centers were black and approximately 12% of these addicts were under age 18. Three out of five of this group were addicted to heroin and nearly 50% had been arrested at least once, graphically illustrating the relationship between drug abuse and delinquency.[42]

Drinking among black teens also increased sharply in only seven years, from 20% in 1972 to 30% in 1979.[32] While drinking has never been as widespread among black youth as among whites, teenage drinking is nonetheless related to self-destructive behavior such as fatal accidents (75% involve alcohol), low school achievement, physical and

mental health problems, and adult alcoholism.[36,44]

Again, the issue is not simply a legal or a moral one. Our concern should be focused on the damage these young people are inflicting on themselves physically, psychologically, and socially. Drug use among teens is very highly correlated to low school achievement, delinquency, and accidental deaths. Drug addition inevitably involves teenagers in activities that will increase access to drugs, whether these involve stealing, dealing, or hustling sex in order to "get high."[14,44] Addicts lose interest in school, work, and gradually deteriorate so that "getting high" becomes the major motivation of each day and they become walking zombies, worthless to themselves, their families, and their communities. Addiction also substantially increases the risk of arrest and imprisonment, of physical and mental illness, and of death by overdosing among black youth.[14,37]

The relationship between all forms of substance abuse and other forms of antisocial behavior has been well-documented, yet there are very few preventive programs aimed specifically at low-income inner-city youth.[37,44] Treatment programs tend to be tailored to the young adult population and are often tied into the criminal justice system as involuntary rehabilitation programs, rather than conceived as early intervention programs for novice substance abusers.

Unwed Teenage Pregnancy

In 1981, a report of the Population Council showed that 83% of babies born to black teenage mothers were born out-of-wedlock, compared to 33% born to white teens.[31] Since 1960, the overall rate of babies born to nonmarried teenage girls (15–19) has increased from 15.3 per 1000 to 25.4 per 1000 in 1978, but whites account for much of this increase.[11] While the birth rate among black teenagers in that age group actually declined from 173 per 1000 in 1957 to 99 per 1000 in 1978, the total number of girls of that age increased by more than 20%, resulting in a much greater increase in the total number of births to black teens.[47]

These are children having children, with profound physical and psychosocial consequences for the girls themselves, as well as negative implications for their babies and their families. First, teenage mothers are more likely to drop out of high school, to go on welfare, to have complications in pregnancy, and to experience physical and psychological problems associated with pregnancy than adult women who bear their first child.[6,11,13] Moreover, teenage mothers are more likely to have larger families, to experience less occupational stability and economic mobility, and to be less competent and effective as parents.[6,11,13] Second, babies born to teenage mothers are more likely to have low birthweight and other perinatal and postnatal problems, more likely to have poor health, and more likely to experience abuse or neglect.[6,11,13] Infant mortality rates are highest among teenage mothers and nearly twice as high among blacks (21.7 per 1000 live births in 1978) as among whites. If they survive, these children tend to be less healthy, less academically successful in school, more likely to grow up in a single-parent, welfare-dependent family, and more likely to become single parents themselves.[6,13] Third, the effects of premature fa-

therhood on the youthful male partners of these teenage mothers has only recently been of interest to researchers. Several studies have found that, compared to their peers who had not fathered children, these young men were more likely to attain a lower educational level and lower occupational status, to have larger families, and to experience unstable marriages.[6,13]

The impact of these illegitimate births on black families has yet to be fully understood and documented. However, some sociological studies suggest that children reared in single-parent homes have fewer competent role models and fewer social supports, which, in turn, limits their ability to grow up in successfully functioning families, to develop satisfactory heterosexual relationships, and to form stable family units of their own.[6,13,26,47]

In 1980, nearly 44% of black children under the age of 18 lived in female-headed, single-parent households, half of which were classified as below the poverty level.[47] Thus, the trend toward more black teenage single mothers may have devastating long-term effects on the structure and functioning of the black family and, ultimately, on the stability of the black community.

Suicide

The final and most alarming indicator is the increasing phenomenon of suicide among black teens and young adults. In the 15–24 age group, the suicide rate for black (and other nonwhite) males in 1960 was 5.3 per 100,000; for black females it was 1.5 per 100,000. In 1979, it had increased nearly three-fold for black males to *14.4* per 100,000 and more than doubled for black females to *3.4* per 100,000.[31] While suicide rates among blacks are still lower than whites of the same sex and age, it has been suggested that the figures would be much higher if causes of death among blacks, in general, were reported as reliably as are causes of death among whites. For example, if suspected cases of suicide by single-car accidents, deliberate drug overdoses, victim-precipitated homicides, and other violent accidents were included in the statistics, the suicide rates would be significantly higher, particularly since the rates of homicide and other types of violent accidents are higher among nonwhite youth.[22] In a recent analysis of long-term trends in adolescent suicide, Holinger and Offer[23] demonstrated the correlation between adolescent population changes and adolescent suicide rates in the United States and suggested that higher rates may reflect increased peer competition—for colleges, jobs, and access to services—that occurs during periods of adolescent population growth. Since black adolescents are clearly in a more disadvantaged competitive position compared to whites, this may very well contribute to their feelings of hopelessness and thereby increase their vulnerability to suicidal behavior.

STRATEGIES FOR INTERVENTION

This brief review of six social indicators presents a grim and depressing portrait of the plight of black youth in contemporary American society. It also suggests that the gatekeepers and guardians of our social institutions have somehow ignored, neglected, or even colluded against the needs of these youth. In many of the largest cities, one can drive through black ghetto neighborhoods and see dozens of unem-

ployed youth drinking on street corners, buying drugs in alleys, or hustling a variety of "hot goods." Many represent the second and third generation of families on welfare, both unemployed and unemployable.[1,17]

While our affluent society has virtually written off this group, they continue to grow and constitute a burgeoning army of alienated and angry youth. As the gap between the "haves" and the "have notes" widens, this group will be further disadvantaged by their inability to participate in an increasingly technocratic and computerized society. The riots of the 1960s and 1970s will seem pale by comparison to the potential widespread violence that may be triggered by an inevitable confrontation between the "haves" and the "have nots" over shrinking natural and material resources. This danger is increasingly exacerbated by those conservative politicians and spokesmen who foster a growing public perception of black youth as welfare cheaters and antisocial parasites, as threats to the "American Way of Life."

The current status of black youth is one of the most severe and most challenging social problems ever to confront the helping professions, yet it is also one of the least recognized and least effectively addressed in terms of research, policy formulation, and service programs. In view of the declining commitment of the federal government and the shrinking resources of state, county, and local governments to deal with these pervasive problems, it is incumbent upon mental health and social service professionals to develop innovative and cost-efficient programs and services aimed at alleviating these problems

One productive way to address these problems would be for persons in the helping professions to develop relationships and build coalitions with private, nonprofit organizations, civic groups, and churches that serve the black community. These groups should work collaboratively to identify problem areas, establish priorities, and develop programs and services specifically tailored to the needs of black youth.

Programmatic Needs and Priorities

There are at least six primary areas in which the coordinated efforts of professionals and community leaders are needed to attack the massive problems of black youth: *1)* alternative secondary educational programs; *2)* employment programs; *3)* sex education and family planning programs; *4)* comprehensive services and child care programs for teenage parents; *5)* delinquency prevention and early intervention programs; and *6)* drug prevention and counseling programs. All of these areas have implications for the prevention of suicide and self-destructive behavior among black youth; the need for program development is urgent. Most crucial to the current stabilization of black youth are education, employment, and sex education/family planning programs; these are the areas that demand priority attention.

Alternative secondary education. As Hobbs and Robinson[21] pointed out, recent research has indicated a need for greater attention to the promotion of cognitive competence in adolescents, particularly those with a background of socioeconomic or educational disadvantage. While the government has spent millions of dollars on early childhood education programs such as Head Start, minimal attention has been paid to

the needs of older youth with learning disabilities and to high school dropouts. However, these authors cited a National Institute of Education report which positively evaluated several compensatory education programs which have shown promising results in increasing cognitive skills and achievement levels for these students.[21] Flexible curricula, including work-study programs, can be designed for those students who cannot seem to benefit from the traditional curriculum, yet must develop marketable skills for entry-level employment. Street academies, such as the one sponsored by the Bay Area Urban League in Oakland, California, have been successful in reclaiming hard-core dropouts who have chronic records of failure and rejection in public schools. Since so many black youths drop out or are forced out of school due to academic or attitudinal factors, mental health professionals can offer consultation to school personnel to institute system change regarding the reduction of truancy, school failure, classroom disruption, and violence. "Project Return," in Irvington, N.J., is an excellent example of a multidisciplinary approach to helping teenagers in a predominantly black school district return to regular classrooms—by modifying teacher attitudes, classroom organization, and administrative procedures, and by involving parents and students in the development of educational policies and practices.[24] Additionally, urban secondary schools with limited financial resources and facilities must find creative ways of utilizing volunteers as teacher aides, community liaison workers, athletic coaches, and performing arts specialists. Several models of such innovative programs have been initiated in a number of urban school systems and have shown early promising results.[8,10,20] As has been recently demonstrated in Chicago, appeals can also be made to local businesses to "adopt-a-school" and provide that school with tax-deductible donations of computers, technical books and supplies, employee tutors, and incentive awards for achievement in topics related to business or science.

A recent study for the Rand Corporation found that parental satisfaction with their children's schools was directly related to their perception of involvement and influence in the educational system.[4] This suggests that it is especially important for black parents to involve themselves in all facets of their children's education, to work in collaboration with teachers and administrators, to monitor homework assignments, to establish clear and consistent academic standards, to support disciplinary practices, and to assure a safe learning environment for all youth. More importantly, however, teachers, administrators, and parents must continue to challenge the unfounded assumption that underachieving teenagers and high school dropouts are beyond help and doomed to a life of marginal employment. They must dedicate their energies to the development of appropriate remedial and experimental programs to develop the level of cognitive skills required for survival in a highly technological economy.

Employment. Youth employment programs are inextricably linked to educational attainment. As was pointed out earlier, lack of a high school diploma, particularly among black youth, is highly correlated to unemployment, low wages, job instability, and welfare de-

pendency.[47] Even with federal incentives in the form of wage subsidies for youth employment demonstration programs, the private sector has not seemed able or willing to compensate for jobs lost through cutbacks in youth employment and training programs, such as CETA.[47] In light of reduced state and federal funds, communities must make greater efforts to develop programs at the local level; this requires the cooperative involvement of local government, business, schools, and social service agencies.

One element often missing from youth employment programs is an understanding of the attitudes and behavior of black youth, which have often created unfavorable employer perceptions and reduced interest in hiring them. Social service agencies can cooperate with school counselors to develop job counseling workshops which would be designed to prepare students for the working world by discussing such basic topics as punctuality, responsibility, appropriate dress and language, office manners, positive attitudes, and bureaucratic structure and procedures. The Youth Employment Program of the Oakland, California, Public School System, is a good example of interagency-community cooperation. However, greater effort must be directed to enrolling black professionals and small businessmen in these programs, for they can fulfill the dual purpose of providing jobs and serving as successful role models for black youths.

Hobbs and Robinson[21] argue that due to demographic shifts there will be fewer younger workers in the labor force in the next few decades. Thus, public policy should be geared to increasing the competence and skills of the current adolescent population in order that they will be able to maintain the nation's productive capacity in the years ahead, in spite of their fewer numbers. A corollary to this argument is that black and other nonwhite youth will comprise an increasing proportion of this shrinking youth population, so it is imperative that they obtain the work experience and training they will need in a highly complex economy.[47]

Sex education and family planning. Programs of sex education and family planning clinics must be modified to take into account sociocultural factors and differential attitudes toward sexuality and childbearing which exist among lower-income urban black youth. Some studies have indicated that black teenagers initiate heterosexual activity earlier than whites, use birth control less frequently, and feel less stigma attached to out-of-wedlock pregnancy.[6,13,43,49] Other studies have suggested that the meaning of pregnancy varies in different sociocultural groups, with many black girls viewing it as an entry to adulthood and autonomy.[26,41] Thus, programs that focus on information and referral sources (and that are geared to middle-class white teenagers) may be quite irrelevant and inappropriate to the needs of black teenagers. As many experts have emphasized, programs should be directed to *primary prevention, i.e.,* efforts to reduce the incidence of unplanned teenage pregnancies through comprehensive programs of sex education and family planning services.[6,11,13]

In evaluating the effectiveness of these programs in the schools and the community, several studies have found that black teenagers were less well informed about basic facts and were less

effective users of contraceptives than were whites.[6,13] However, a family planning program sponsored by the Family Planning Service at the University of Pennsylvania School of Medicine, in conjunction with several inner-city high schools, offered educational and emotional support to a group of never-pregnant black females and found that these adolescents were able to use contraceptive services effectively over a three-year period.[30] Similarly, a model program developed by the St. Paul Maternal and Infant Care Project offered comprehensive health care and contraceptive services to inner-city teens through clinics in one junior high school and two senior high schools, with dramatic reductions in birth rates in those schools.[13]

It is also important to recognize the needs of black adolescent males in the area of sex education and family planning. As among white males, this group tends to obtain its information about sexuality from peers and from the mass media, which often leads to misinformation and distortion.[13,39] Since multiple premarital pregnancies are a particular problem among low-income black adolescents, sex education and pregnancy prevention programs should be designed to involve males as well as females.[2,6,13] Some current approaches that may prove to be effective with males and females involve the use of peer counselors in school programs, "rap" groups in community agencies, informal programs through boys' and girls' clubs, youth groups, and other programs that involve the use of well-trained, youthful counselors who are cognizant of differing cultural values among black youth.[2,6,13,39]

Finally, in order to develop effective and culturally relevant family planning programs, professionals must involve black parents and community leaders who are familiar with the deeply ingrained attitudes and social customs that have often reinforced the patterns of premarital sexuality and childbearing in the black community.[12,26,41]

Comprehensive services for teenage parents. At the level of secondary prevention, comprehensive prenatal and postnatal services and adequate child-care services are badly needed for black teenage parents.[6,11,13,28] Evaluation studies of service programs for school-age parents have shown mixed results due to a number of factors, including lack of administrative support, poorly defined target populations and problem issues, inadequate interagency coordination, uneven quality of services, and short-term goals.[6,13,18,48] Moreover, while some of these programs produced positive short-term results in improved maternal and infant health and continuing education, long-term results in the areas of educational attainment, reduction of subsequent pregnancies, or achievement of economic independence were less positive.[6,25] Finally, most of these programs provide for the first-time teenage mother but not for those with higher-order pregnancies, young mothers who are particularly at risk for negative outcomes.[6,13]

The Adolescent Pregnancy Program at Children's Hospital National Medical Center in Washington, D.C., though now defunct due to loss of funds, presented an excellent comprehensive, multidisciplinary approach that offered pregnancy testing, venereal disease screening, family planning and counseling services, prenatal services, labor and delivery services and postpartum

maternal and infant care.[40] This program had several other distinctive features such as parent education, nutrition classes, and continuity of care supervised by a primary nurse. A variety of other innovative programs have shown positive short-term results, such as New York City's Project Redirection, which offers comprehensive services to pregnant teenagers and pairs them with adult volunteer counselors.[28]

Adequate child care services are also significantly lacking for black teenage parents.[6,11,13,25,28] Since these teenagers are unable to continue their education without child care, it is imperative that such services be developed in order to prevent the cycle of school leaving-lack of skills-unemployment-welfare. Further, children of teen parents are at higher risk for child abuse and neglect; relieving these parents of the full-time burden of child care is likely to reduce the incidence of child abuse and result in psychologically and physically healthier children. One immediate and inexpensive way to increase child care facilities for teenage parents would be for black churches to donate their often under-used facilities for weekday child care centers, which could be staffed by volunteers from among the retired and unemployed members of the community. This would minimize the need for paid professional staff and would maximize the use of human resources in the community, as has been demonstrated in the Foster Grandparents Program.

Finally, it is essential that teenage fathers who have long been neglected by program planners, become involved in programs with their pregnant partners so that they can feel a closer bond and greater paternal responsibility for their babies.[2] Since 1981, a model Program, the Teenage Pregnancy and Parenting Program, which offers comprehensive services to teen parents and involves the use of peer counselors, has been in operation at San Francisco General Hospital.[34] Participants in this program are primarily black and Hispanic and the initial results have led to cautious optimism. Similar programs have been funded in eight U.S. communities by the Ford Foundation in order to encourage involvement of teenage fathers, to improve their educational outcomes and to reduce the incidence of subsequent pregnancies.[34]

Delinquency prevention. Approaches to black delinquents through the cooperative efforts of local agencies, businesses, and community groups must also be conceptualized in terms of primary and secondary prevention. Evaluation studies of preventive approaches to delinquency have generally indicated that most programs are ineffective for a variety of reasons, including a failure to specify the target population, failure to match treatment to type of delinquent, and failure to control for variables such as type of offense, age, SES and community support system.[44] Since black delinquents tend to be overrepresented among the category of socialized or subcultural delinquents,[15,44] primary prevention efforts should be aimed at modifying their immediate environments to provide more recreational and cultural programs and to coordinate efforts to reduce the school dropout rate and the youth unemployment rate.[27,44] It seems ironic that publicly funded recreational and cultural programs are usually available for youth

in suburban middle-class communities, while there are few such programs or even adequate facilities for inner-city youth, who are forced to play in trash-littered lots, dangerous city streets, and abandoned buildings. Again, social workers could engage in some "old-fashioned" community organizing to bring together churches, civic groups, and parents who can combine their facilities, resources, and volunteer energies to provide structured recreational programs in safe locations, as well as summer vacation and camp programs; classes in black history and culture, and field trips to museums, cultural events, sports activities, and to local universities, industries and government agencies. While there is no guarantee that any of these activities will reduce delinquency, there is some evidence that communities with extensive youth programs do have lower rates of delinquency.[44] Similarly, any efforts that involve teenagers in productive activities will presumably reduce their energies, motivation, and time for self-destructive and delinquent behavior.

Secondary prevention or early intervention efforts should focus on the establishment of more diversion programs that could be operated by youth service organizations within the community and that could prevent the premature identification and stigmatization as "delinquent" of those with first-time minor offenses. In addition, a range of comprehensive services, such as those offered by public and private agencies in Kentucky, must be available to the heterogeneous population of black delinquents—*e.g.*, prevention of truancy; home-based social and rehabilitative services for the delinquent and his family; day treatment programs which involve remedial education, counseling and recreation; foster care for abused or neglected children; group homes with treatment services; and residential treatment facilities for the more seriously delinquent and disturbed youth.[27] If these approaches are going to be effective with black delinquents, they must be planned in conjunction with black mental health and social welfare professionals and community leaders, they must take into account the sociocultural values and structural barriers of the black community, and they must be staffed by people who are sensitive to those values and realities.

Finally, any programs of secondary or tertiary prevention (rehabilitation) for black delinquents should be linked to the improvement of educational skills and vocational training, since these types of programs have generally had the most positive outcomes and, particularly for this group, are more likely to attack the underlying socioeconomic causes of their antisocial behavior.[18]

Drug counseling. In terms of primary prevention, a recent review of evaluations of 127 drug abuse prevention programs concluded that these programs "produced only minor effects on drug use behavior and attitudes," with the eight most effective programs designed with peer or process orientations rather than an information-only approach.[37] Moreover, current programs of drug education, like sex education, rarely take into account ethnic differences in attitudes, usage patterns, and responses to treatment.[3,16,33,36] Such programs must also take into account the social context, the values, and the realities of the inner-city teenager's life, which are

very different than those of suburban, white, middle-class youth. Urban black youth are exposed earlier to a variety of drugs, may be involved at an early age as "runners" or "spotters" for drug dealers, and tend to accept the pervasive presence of drugs as a fact of community life. Current high school drug education programs fail to recognize that inner-city youth usually have an earlier exposure and greater level of sophistication about drugs than do middle-class suburban youth. In order to be effective, drug education and prevention programs must involve parents and community leaders, as well as peer counselors, not only to inform these teenagers about the dangers of drug abuse, but to set up supportive peer groups where mutual contracts can be made to avoid drugs and develop alternative forms of socializing. Parents must be willing to monitor the behavior and moods of their children, to confront them about suspicious friends and activities, and to give them positive reinforcement for staying "clean." Moreover, parents themselves must be supported and reinforced by community leaders who are willing to take a public stance against drug dealing and drug use in the black community.

With regard to secondary and tertiary prevention, most federally funded drug counseling and rehabilitation programs are aimed at older youth and at the harder drugs such as cocaine and heroin.[42] However, black children in the inner-city are exposed to drugs at increasingly younger ages, so more locally-sponsored programs need to be developed with a focus on early intervention and prevention of long-term drug abuse. These programs could effectively utilize parents and volunteers, since the preadolescent group is a somewhat more captive audience in elementary and junior high schools, as well as through youth organizations such as Boy Scouts and Girl Scouts, Little League and other team sports, and musical and religious groups. These supervised sports, recreational, social, and religious activities could also serve as a vehicle for informal drug education and prevention programs, involving parents and youth leaders in approaches specifically tailored to the target group of teenagers. Such ongoing programs would be particularly effective in communities where schedules of intermittent reinforcement are necessary for many adolescents to maintain drug-free behavior. Recent efforts of the mass media to publicize the extent of adolescent drug abuse in America, through programs such as "The Chemical People," have been aimed at a middle-class audience, yet these programs have also fostered local, well-coordinated, community strategies to combat drug abuse; perhaps these strategies may filter down through the widespread involvement of parents, schools, social agencies, and treatment centers to low-income black youth.[35]

Finally, the increase in suicide rates and violent, self-destructive accidents among black youth can probably best be addressed indirectly, through policies and programs of primary prevention that will reduce their feelings of helplessness, hopelessness, depression, and alienation—all of which have been related to suicidal behavior in adolescence.[19] As noted earlier, such programs should be aimed at alleviating the social and economic conditions which have made black adolescents, and particularly black males, more vulnerable

to school withdrawal or failure, unemployment, teenage parenthood, drug abuse, and delinquency.

CONCLUSIONS

It is becomingly increasingly clear that all of the phenomena discussed above are interrelated and, in combination, operate to reduce the life chances for black youth, to restrict their social mobility, and to move them toward a permanently disadvantaged caste status. The programs and services discussed here represent only a limited and relatively superficial approach to this complex issue. A truly effective preventive strategy must evolve from significant social and structural changes and must ultimately stem from initiatives at the federal government level to develop a comprehensive national policy for families and children that would include an adequate, guaranteed income; full employment; health care services; adequate housing and recreational facilities; vocational training programs for youth; family planning services; child care services; and coordinated programs to assist dysfunctional families. Since such a national family policy is the ultimate panacea and unlikely to be adopted or instituted in the foreseeable future, helping professionals must settle for limited goals and circumscribed programs to prevent future generations of black youth from becoming permanently consigned to an underclass.

This paper has attempted to dramatize the plight of black urban youth, who are, in several significant social dimensions, worse off *vis a vis* the dominant society than they were two decades ago. The statistics are startling and speak for themselves. But who speaks for the black youth? The hour is late and the possibility of a permanent youthful black "underclass" is coming closer and closer to reality. If members of the helping professions do not recognize the enormity of this situation, if we fail to develop creative solutions to this growing malignancy in our social fabric, we will share the responsibility for the inevitable outcome. If we are to avert a society split along racial and economic lines, we must expand the resources of our professional social service agencies by building collaborative relationships with local schools, churches, businesses, and community organizations serving the black community, and by recruiting and training black parents and volunteers to assist in the planning, development, and implementation of innovative and cost-effective programs of prevention and early intervention. Through such creative initiatives, professionals will be able to demonstrate a continued commitment to the process of building a society where each child can enjoy an equal opportunity to grow, to learn, to work, and to love.

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For reprints: Jewelle Taylor Gibbs, M.S.W., Ph.D., School of Social Welfare, SW 01, 120 Haviland Hall, University of California, Berkeley, Calif. 94720